management coordination, and mapping applications. While welcomed by most member countries, the initiative was blocked by Pakistan. Renamed the South Asia Satellite, the effort still went through, with the launch in 2017.

While continuing to pursue opportunities through SAARC, India has been seeking alternative institutional means of reviving regional cooperation. One such effort has involved the BIMSTEC. This organization was established in 1997 and headquartered in Dhaka. Membership initially included the Bay of Bengal countries of India, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Thailand, and Sri Lanka, and Nepal and Bhutan were subsequently added. As the membership includes much of South Asia, but not China and Pakistan, it opens avenues for Indian regional leadership and serves as a bridge to Southeast Asia. [9] A BIMSTEC Summit was held after many years in 2016 at India's initiation, on the side lines of the BRICS Summit in Goa. But while it has a large number of areas of work, it was for too long poorly resourced and received insufficient political investment. Recent efforts—including a revised charter in 2022—streamlined the group's areas of focus, and India has also increased its financial and diplomatic investment in the organization. [10]

Informal issue-specific networks might also be useful in the region. Cooperation on maritime domain awareness involving India, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives has been ongoing, and now extended to other Indian Ocean countries. Similar cooperation could also extend to the four countries connected by land: India, Bangladesh, Nepal and Bhutan or BBIN. One such proposal involved a motor vehicle agreement (MVA). The proposal met with opposition in Bhutan, which was worried about the influx of Bangladeshi and Indian vehicles into the country. Nonetheless, the prospects of greater issue-specific cooperation among clusters of countries in South Asia needs to be more fully explored. [11]